
Radiohead review – bards of the apocalypse return for a brutal bacchanal

Published by

Stephen Phelan

Estimated reading time

4 min

Added on

2025-11-05

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/music/2025/nov/05/radiohead-live-review-movistar-arena-madrid-spain-thom-yorke>

Radiohead review – bards of the apocalypse return for a brutal bacchanal

Almost 10 years have passed since [Radiohead](#) released a new record, and more than seven since they were last seen on stage. Living through that period has felt like moving further and faster into the future that their songs often sounded so worried about. Animal-borne diseases and invading armies, bomb shelters and endless rainstorms, falling skies and collapsing infrastructure – 'twas all foretold in the lyric sheets of the ever-fretful [Thom Yorke](#).

His reputation as a soothsayer has probably been overstated as the band's myth has grown in their absence, but if the frontman is a genius (the jury is still out and may never come back in, their verdict deferred more by politics than musicianship) then he's hardly the only monumental talent in the lineup. For all the brilliant records Yorke has made lately, including several with bandmate Jonny Greenwood in [their looser-limbed trio the Smile](#), the faithful have been holding out a geological age to see the full five back together.

Now, without much warning, nor any particular reason, nor any new music to sell us (that we know of), they have returned to play [short residencies in a few European cities](#). Performing in the round, they take and switch positions behind a gossamer projection screen that initially seems like some kind of shield. As it turns out, no such protection is needed. This is not a fragile re-emergence.

"Shell smashed, juices flowing," sings Yorke on opener Let Down, and it makes sense that they would start again with that one. A deep cut from [OK Computer](#) that has long been a fan favourite, its recent adoption by teens on TikTok gave the band their closest thing to a big hit this century. Gorgeous, oddly weightless, gently self-mocking – Yorke's mordant joking about his own tendency towards maudlin "drivel" might be as under-recognised as Kafka's – it strikes a peculiar note of hope-against-doubt, bequeathed from gen X to gen Z.

On this outing, the shimmer of the vocal and Greenwood's curious guitar melody (played in a different time signature to the other instruments) are given colossal oomph by an almost overpowering rhythm section. This sets the tone for the night, too, as the top end sometimes suffers from the cavern effect common to arenas of this size, while drummer Phil Selway, auxiliary percussionist Chris Vatalaro, and Jonny's bassist brother Colin compensate with a stunning show of force on mid-to-late career tracks 2+2=5, Bloom and Ful Stop.

The elder Greenwood has always been Radiohead's secret weapon, his manner suggesting the offer of a nice cuppa while his playing can range from loverman soulfulness to borderline brutality. His basslines have walked the listener through the most forbidding passages of their studio material and tonight's selections from Kid A – Everything In Its Right Place, Idioteque – complete their 25-year transition from icy sonic shocks to crowd-pleasing, floor-filling heaters.

By 15 Step even the upper tiers of seated sections are bouncing like babies to those tricky drum patterns while Yorke reminds them that "it comes to us all", whatever "it" is. Old age ... or death, most likely. Yorke is almost 60 now and spry as hell, but also grey-bearded as a sea dog while he dances little jigs around the deck to The National Anthem and its stupidly great bassline, which he apparently wrote when he was 16.

Yorke has always kept one eye on the prancing spectres of elders like Mick Jagger, and one ear out for the sound of legacy acts spinning their wheels. That is absolutely not how Radiohead come

across here. Their fanbase is more prone to purism and perversity than others, maybe, and some will inevitably quibble about the relative lack of choice picks from albums A Moon Shaped Pool or The Bends, though beloved early-ish single Fake Plastic Trees "blows through the ceiling" on that line much more explosively than on the recorded version.

In the past, live performance has expressed Radiohead's clear relief at being out of the studio, and alleviated of the compositional pressure that seemed to almost wreck them every time. Their energy tonight might mean something else, but the relief is surely felt by anyone who ever loved this band – it's not just fun, it's an absolute joy. Yorke, for his part, says little other than "gracias". There are many who feel he should have said a lot more, and [a lot louder, in recent years](#). And there are others who remember well the nervy young guy who seemed so freaked out by the speed and direction of our supposed progress back in the early days of the iMac, who would still elect him as the very fellow to sing to us in our present state of terminal velocity.

[The setlist](#)

Let Down
2 + 2 = 5
Sit Down. Stand Up
Bloom
Lucky
Ful Stop
The Gloaming
Myxomatosis
No Surprises
Videotape
Weird Fishes/Arpeggi
Everything in Its Right Place
15 Step
The National Anthem
Daydreaming
A Wolf at the Door
Bodysnatchers
Idioteque

Encore

Fake Plastic Trees
Subterranean Homesick Alien
Paranoid Android
How to Disappear Completely
You and Whose Army?
There There
Karma Police

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.